

77 Asa

A reforming king who trusted God against a vast army, then leaned on men in his later years.

Asa, Solomon's great-grandson, was the third king of Judah after the kingdom divided, and reigned forty-one years. He began well. He tore down idols, removed his own grandmother as queen mother because of her idol, and led Judah to renew its covenant with God. When a huge army from Cush marched against him, he prayed a short, honest prayer and God gave the victory. But later, facing a smaller threat from Israel, he paid a pagan king for help, and jailed the prophet who rebuked him. His life asks whether faith that starts strong will finish strong.

At a glance

<i>Name</i>	Hebrew <i>Asa</i> . The meaning is uncertain; some suggest "healer"
<i>Family</i>	Son of Abijah (Abijam); father of Jehoshaphat (1 Kings 15:8, 24)
<i>Queen mother</i>	Maachah, whom he removed (1 Kings 15:10, 13)
<i>Reign</i>	41 years in Jerusalem, c. 911–870 BC (1 Kings 15:10)
<i>Key places</i>	Jerusalem, the Kidron valley, Mareshah, Ramah
<i>Key people</i>	Azariah, Hanani the seer, Zerah, Baasha, Ben-hadad
<i>New Testament</i>	Named in the genealogy of Jesus (Matthew 1:7–8)

"For the eyes of the LORD run to and fro throughout the whole earth, to shew himself strong in the behalf of them whose heart is perfect toward him."

2 Chronicles 16:9, KJV

The life of Asa

Dates are approximate (BC) and follow the house chronology. Years are counted from the start of his reign. Chronicles' "thirty-sixth year" (2 Chronicles 16:1) is a known puzzle; see the next page.

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| c. 911 BC
<i>Year 1</i> | <div>● Becomes king</div> <p>After his father Abijah's short reign, Asa takes the throne of Judah. He does what is right in God's eyes, as David his father did. <i>1 Kings 15:8-11; 2 Chronicles 14:1-2</i></p> |
| c. 911-901 BC
<i>Years 1-10</i> | <div>● Reform and rest</div> <p>He removes foreign altars, images and groves, and commands Judah to seek God. The land is quiet for ten years, and he builds fortified cities. <i>2 Chronicles 14:1-7</i></p> |
| Before his 15th year | <div>● Victory over Zerah</div> <p>Zerah the Ethiopian comes against Judah with a huge army. Asa cries to God at Mareshah, and Judah routs the invaders and carries off great spoil. <i>2 Chronicles 14:9-15</i></p> |
| c. 896 BC
<i>15th year</i> | <div>● Covenant renewed</div> <p>Stirred by the prophet Azariah, Asa removes more idols and gathers Judah and many from the north. They swear with shouting to seek God with all their heart. <i>2 Chronicles 15:1-15</i></p> |
| Later in his reign | <div>● Buys help from Syria</div> <p>When Baasha of Israel fortifies Ramah on Judah's border, Asa sends temple silver and gold to Ben-hadad of Syria. Ben-hadad attacks the north, and Baasha withdraws. <i>1 Kings 15:16-22; 2 Chronicles 16:1-6</i></p> |
| Soon after | <div>● Rebuked by Hanani</div> <p>The seer Hanani says he trusted Syria instead of God. Asa is angry, puts the seer in prison, and oppresses some of the people. <i>2 Chronicles 16:7-10</i></p> |
| c. 872-870 BC
<i>Years 39-41</i> | <div>● Disease and death</div> <p>His feet become severely diseased, yet he seeks physicians rather than God. He dies in his forty-first year and is buried with great honour. <i>1 Kings 15:23-24; 2 Chronicles 16:12-14</i></p> |

Key activities

2 Chronicles 16:1 dates Baasha's move to Asa's 36th year, but 1 Kings 16:8 says Baasha died in Asa's 26th year. Some scholars count the 36 years from the division of the kingdom, and others suspect a copying error.

- 1 Cleared away idols.** He took away foreign altars, high places, images and groves, and told Judah to seek the God of their fathers. *2 Chronicles 14:2-5*
- 2 Built in peace.** He used the quiet years to fortify cities with walls, towers, gates and bars. *2 Chronicles 14:6-7*
- 3 Prayed before battle.** Facing Zerah's army, he prayed, "help us, O LORD our God; for we rest on thee." *2 Chronicles 14:11*
- 4 Listened to a prophet.** Azariah told him, "The LORD is with you, while ye be with him." Asa took courage and acted. *2 Chronicles 15:1-8*
- 5 Removed his grandmother.** He deposed Maachah as queen mother because of her idol in a grove. He cut it down and burned it by the brook Kidron. *1 Kings 15:13; 2 Chronicles 15:16*
- 6 Led a covenant renewal.** Judah and settlers from Ephraim, Manasseh and Simeon gathered in Jerusalem, sacrificed, and swore to seek God. *2 Chronicles 15:9-15*
- 7 Bribed a foreign king.** He sent treasure from the temple and palace to Ben-hadad to break Syria's treaty with Baasha. *1 Kings 15:18-20; 2 Chronicles 16:2-4*
- 8 Imprisoned the messenger.** When Hanani rebuked him, Asa raged and put him in the prison house. *2 Chronicles 16:7-10*
- 9 Sought physicians, not God.** In his final illness he looked only to doctors for help. *2 Chronicles 16:12*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Asa.

Old Testament

1 Kings 15:8–24; 2 Chronicles 14–16	Two accounts; Chronicles is fuller
1 Kings 15:14	High places remained, yet his heart was perfect with the LORD
1 Kings 22:43	Jehoshaphat walks in the ways of Asa his father
Jeremiah 41:9	The pit Asa dug against Baasha, still known later
Echo: Psalm 20:7	"Some trust in chariots, and some in horses"
Echo: Jeremiah 17:5	"Cursed be the man that trusteth in man"

New Testament

Matthew 1:7–8	In the royal line of Jesus
Echo: 2 Timothy 4:7	"I have finished my course"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* Compare Asa's prayer in 2 Chronicles 14:11 with his actions in 2 Chronicles 16:1–4. What changed?
2. *Understand:* Hanani says God looks for people "whose heart is perfect toward him" (2 Chronicles 16:9). What does that mean, since Asa was far from sinless?
3. *Apply:* Asa trusted God in a crisis but not in a smaller problem. Where do you rely on yourself because a problem seems small?
4. *Apply:* Asa reacted angrily to correction. Who has permission to tell you hard truths, and how do you usually respond?